Chandra Dhakal

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

PhD economist with 10+ years of experience in econometrics, causal inference, program evaluation, and economic modeling. Lead the Data to Policy program at the CDC Foundation (contract to CDC), advising ministries of health across 19 countries on evidence-based resource allocation. Deep expertise in quasi-experimental methods on large administrative and survey datasets, cost-effectiveness and budget impact analysis, and decision-analytic modeling (Markov models, microsimulation). Author of 25+ peer-reviewed publications.

CORE COMPETENCIES

Causal Inference: difference-in-differences, instrumental variables, regression discontinuity, synthetic control, propensity score matching, quasi-experimental design
Economic Evaluation: cost-effectiveness, cost-utility, budget impact analysis, QALY/DALY estimation
Decision Modeling: Markov models, microsimulation, decision trees (TreeAge)
Methods: program evaluation, machine learning, Bayesian statistics, survival analysis, forecasting, time series, text mining
Tools: R, Python (pandas, NumPy, scikit-learn), Stata, SAS, SQL, AWS, Tableau, Power BI, LaTeX

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Health Economist, Data to Policy Lead Dec 2021 – Present
CDC Foundation (contract to CDC), Division of Global Health Protection, Atlanta, GA

- Lead the Data to Policy program under the Bloomberg Philanthropies Data for Health Initiative, partnering with ministries of health across 19 countries to strengthen evidence-based priority setting and resource allocation.
- Design and lead economic evaluations (cost-effectiveness, cost-utility, budget impact) and decision-analytic models assessing CDC investments in global health protection.
- Apply econometric, quasi-experimental, and machine learning methods to large administrative, household, and retail scanner datasets (billions of observations).
- Built global capacity through international training-of-trainers workshops in health economics and decision modeling for 100+ economists and policymakers.

Graduate Research Assistant Aug 2016 – Dec 2021
University of Georgia, Athens, GA

- Estimated structural demand systems (Exact Affine Stone Index) on retail scanner data; built small-area price indexes for all U.S. counties, cutting processing time by 50%.
- Published research on unemployment insurance, food hardship, and consumer behavior in the *Journal of Policy Analysis and Management* and other peer-reviewed journals.

Research Assistant / Data Analyst Jan 2015 – Jul 2016
Texas Tech University, Lubbock, TX

- Applied econometric and dynamic optimization models to agricultural programs; published findings on optimal input use in the *Journal of Agricultural and Applied Economics* (2020 Outstanding Article Award).

Assistant Professor of Agricultural Economics Jan 2014 – Dec 2014
Tribhuvan University, Kathmandu, Nepal

Research Associate / Data Analyst Jan 2012 – Dec 2013
Nepal Development Research Institute, Kathmandu, Nepal

EDUCATION

Ph.D., Econometrics and Quantitative Economics — University of Georgia, 2022
M.S., Statistics — University of Georgia, 2021
M.S., Applied Economics — Texas Tech University, 2016
B.S., Agriculture — Tribhuvan University, Nepal

SELECTED PUBLICATIONS

- Dhakal, C., Y. Luo, S. Wang, and C. Zhen. (2023). Unemployment insurance benefit reduction and food hardship. *Journal of Policy Analysis and Management.*
- Neupane, S., W. J. Florkowski, and C. Dhakal. (2024). Trends and disparities in diabetes prevalence in the United States from 2012 to 2022. *American Journal of Preventive Medicine*, 67(2), 299–302.
- Acharya, B. and C. Dhakal. (2021). Implementation of state vaccine incentive lottery programs and uptake of COVID-19 vaccinations in the US. *JAMA Network Open.*
- Dhakal, C., K. Lange, M. N. Parajulee, and E. Segarra. (2019). Dynamic optimization of nitrogen in plateau cotton yield functions. *Journal of Agricultural and Applied Economics*, 51(3), 385–401. (2020 Outstanding Article Award)

25+ peer-reviewed publications — full list at dhakalck.github.io

HONORS

2020 Outstanding Article Award, *Journal of Agricultural and Applied Economics* | **2014 Early Career Research Scholar**, USAID Feed the Future Innovation Lab | Graduate travel awards, University of Georgia (2018, 2019)